

5. Celebrate variety

Environment: Agrobiodiversity is an important strategy for facing the challenges of climate change, as it offers more flexible climate adaptation strategies, thus supporting food security and resource saving (Fischlin et al. 2007). Widening food choices allows for more creativity in our diet, making it easier to plan more sustainable diets. Coupling variety with highlighting seasonal and local products could help to boost local economies and save resources. Seasonality is also important. The CF of vegetables and fruit grown in heated greenhouses can be increased four-fold (Clune et al. 2017). Refrigerated transport of plant-based food and long-term refrigerated storage of “out of season” vegetables and fruit in warehouses can be a significant source of CO₂ equivalents (Hospido et al. 2009, James & Jasmes 2010, Wakeland et al. 2012). Generally, only when local markets are affected by seasonal constraints which strongly limit food variety (cold climates), long-distance supply chains may be more advantageous compared with greenhouse food production or with long-term food storage throughout the seasons (Wakeland et al. 2012).

Health: Dietary diversity has long been recognized as a key element of high-quality diets. Increasing the variety of foods across and within food groups is recommended in most dietary guidelines internationally, as a means to ensure adequate intake of essential nutrients and to promote good health (Ruel, 2003). Simplification of human diets associated with increased accessibility of inexpensive commodities and erosion of agrobiodiversity lead to nutrient deficiencies and excess energy consumption (Johns & Eyzaguirre, 2006). Fruits, minor vegetables, and leaves used as condiments, spices, or sauce ingredients can be grown in small quantities and add variety and essential nutrients to diets otherwise dominated by staple foods. Agrobiodiversity is an underexplored avenue for giving both food producers and consumers access to greater dietary diversity (Johns et al. 2006).